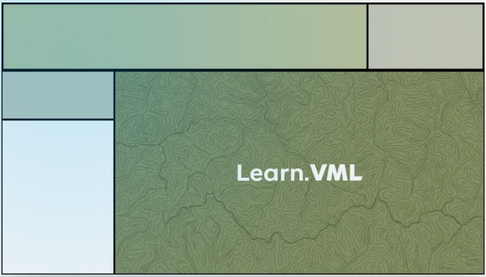
Marve Afo
Product designer

VML

Turning a Junk Drawer Into a Design System



T.L.D.R.

Rebuilt VML's global LMS from a nav-less 'junk drawer' into a coded, design system.

- Drove 89% org-wide adoption
- 316% more learning time
- 230% more active users

Role

Sole product and visual designer
on a six-person learning team,
reporting to the Global VP of Learning.

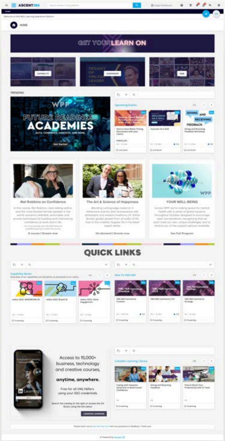
Key Stakeholders

- VP, Global Head of Learning
- Global Director of HR Technology
- Regional Learning Directors

Sneak Peek 👁

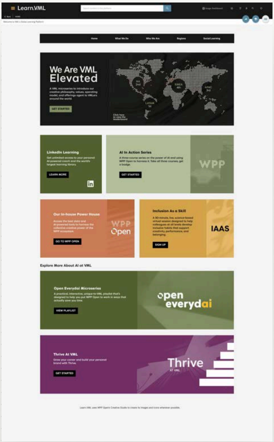
Before

Original home page


ASCENT360
GET YOUR LEARN ON
FUTURE READINESS ACADEMIES
QUICK LINKS

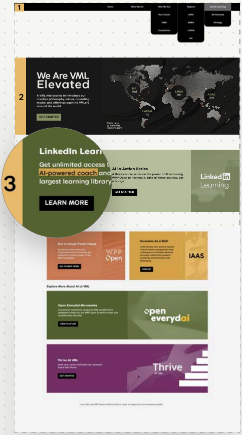
After

Revised home page


Learn.VML
We Are VML Elevated
WPP
WPP Open
IAAS
open everydai
Thrive

A Closer Look

Revised home page with highlighted callouts



1
2
3
NA
2nd
EMEA
4th
APAC
3rd
LATAM
1st
GET STARTED
LEARN MORE
GET STARTED
Linked in
Learning
WPP
Open
IAAS
open
everydai
Thrive
AT VML

We Are VML Elevated

A VML microseries to introduce our creative philosophy, values, operating model, and offerings agent to VMLers around the world.

Click here to view the leaderboard

LinkedIn Learn

Get unlimited access t AI-powered coach and largest learning library

AI In Action Series

A three-course series on the power of AI and using WPP Open to harness it. Take all three courses, get a badge.

Our In-house Power House

Inclusion As a Skill

Explore More About AI at VML

Open Everydai Microseries

Thrive At VML

What Changed

Same Page, New System

1) Real navigation
A coded nav bar replaced links buried inside links.

2) New hero
A customizable coded hero spotlights one initiative instead of competing banners.

3) Real text
Headlines and descriptions are live text, so search can find them.

Fewer cards
Organized content rows replaced dozens of scattered tiles.

One block system
Every section uses the same component library, so pages stay consistent.

Branded throughout
VML colors, textures, and the custom font run site-wide.

Clear CTAs
One consistent button style across every section.

The Problem

Leadership Called It A Junk Drawer

Unorganized
VML's learning platform had no main navigation, just links buried inside links. Leadership called it a junk drawer. For a creative agency that sells branded experiences, a platform that looked like an afterthought undercut the very learning it asked employees to take seriously.

Then VMLY&R merged with Wunderman Thompson to become VML. That meant two legacy LMSs, a new brand kit, and new leadership, all needed one platform to teach employees who the new company was.

4 Step Fix

Audit

Systemize

Brand

Customize

UX Audit

An Audit Highlighted 3 Failures

Before redesigning anything, I ran a heuristic audit, clicking through the platform as a new employee would and annotating screenshots wherever the experience broke down.

It was hard to find pages
There was no main navigation, search was easy to miss and laid out backwards. Many courses were buried in links inside links.
There was not a clear info heiarchy.

The interface didn't explain itself
Icons were misleading (the "add content" icon looked like an email reply), labels were vague ("Share this view?"), and there were two filter buttons doing one job.

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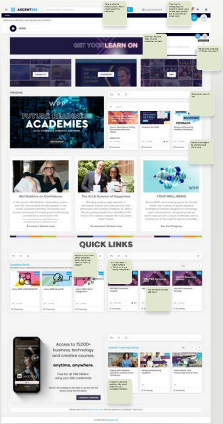
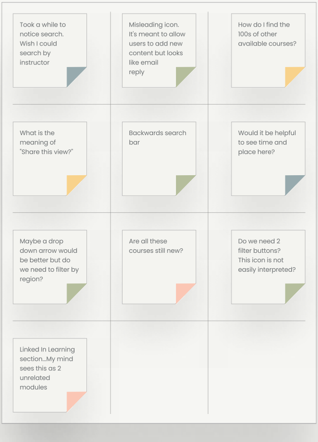




Took a while to notice search. Wish I could search by instructor

Misleading icon. It's meant to allow users to add new content but looks like email reply

How do I find the 100s of other available courses?

What is the meaning of "Share this view?"

Backwards search bar

Would it be helpful to see time and place here?

Maybe a drop down arrow would be better but do we need to filter by region?

Are all these courses still new?

Do we need 2 filter buttons? This icon is not easily interpreted?

Linked In Learning section...My mind sees this as 2 unrelated modules

The Constraints

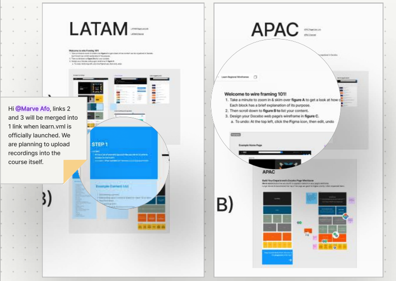
4 Blocks, No Nav, No Custom Fonts.

Limited customization
This needed real information architecture, not a new coat of style. Docebo locked us into fixed content blocks, with no native navigation and no way to load our own fonts. Whatever we built had to work inside those walls.

Drawing Board

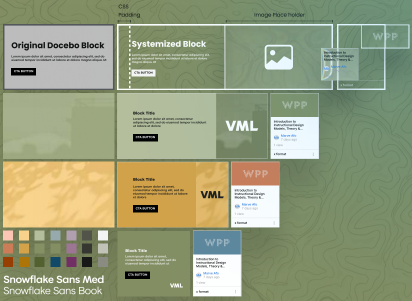
I Fixed Structure Before Style

With the audit done, I facilitated a session introducing learning directors from four global regions to FigJam, so we could share and compare sitemap needs in one place. I then helped each region build lo-fi mockups of their own LMS pages.


LATAM
APAC
Learn Regional Wireframes
STEP 1
Example Content List
Example Home Page
Build Your Department's Docebo Page Wireframe
B)
B)

Hi @Marve Afo, links 2 and 3 will be merged into 1 link when learn.vml is officially launched. We are planning to upload recordings into the course itself.

Welcome to wire framing 101!
1. Take a minute to zoom in & skim over **figure A** to get a look at how c
   Each block has a brief explanation of its purpose.
2. Then scroll down to **figure B to** list your content.
3. Design your Docebo web page's wireframe in **figure C.**
   a. To undo: At the top left, click the Figma icon, then edit, undo


CSS
Padding
Image Place holder
Original Docebo Block
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut
CTA BUTTON
Systemized Block
Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit, sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut
CTA BUTTON
WPP
Introduction to Instructional Design Models, Theory &...
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WPP
Introduction to Instructional Design Models, Theory &...
Marve Afo
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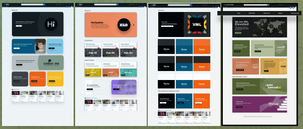
x format
Block Title
CTA BUTTON
VML
WPP
Block Title
CTA BUTTON
VML
WPP
Snowflake Sans Med
Snowflake Sans Book

I Turned Limits Into a System

I reverse engineered Docebo's content blocks in Figma, measuring the real thing so anything I built translated exactly when shipped. I systemized the four block sizes into a lego-like component library with swap-in textures and swatches from the new **VML** brand kit, built all 14 core pages for the post-merger relaunch, enabling fast, consistent mockups for easy sharing and approval.


Hi
Inclusion
VML
We Are VML Elevated
Thrive

I did many iterations of branding and design before reaching the current product.

The Decisions

Readable Text Made Learning Findable

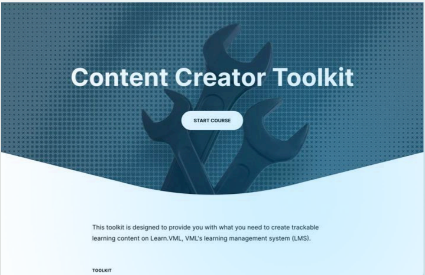
The old platform rendered most of its text as images. That meant no search, and no screen reader support. I rebuilt everything as real, readable text. Not a stylistic choice.
A functional one.

Fewer Cards Made Pages Faster

Certain key pages were trying to load up to fifty content cards at once. It wasn't just cluttered, it was slow. I restructured all main pages into one hero block, a handful of organized content block rows, and a single channel feed at the bottom. Fixed the mess and the load time in the same move.

Governance Made the System Last

Good design can't fix active misuse on its own. The team built tagging rules with regional leads owning them; I built the training that made it stick, teaching teams exactly how to organize what they uploaded so better tagging meant content actually got found.


Content Creator Toolkit

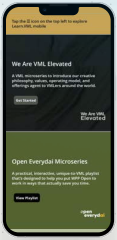
START COURSE

This toolkit is designed to provide you with what you need to create trackable learning content on Learn.VML, VML's learning management system (LMS).

TOOLKIT

1 Block for Mobile

I redesigned every page for mobile using a single block: the smallest of Docebo's four sizes. It fit the screen perfectly, so stacking it gave every page a clean, consistent layout that kept the branding and hierarchy intact.


Tap the ☰ icon on the top left to explore Learn.VML mobile

We Are VML Elevated

A VML microseries to introduce our creative philosophy, values, operating model, and offerings agent to VMLers around the world.

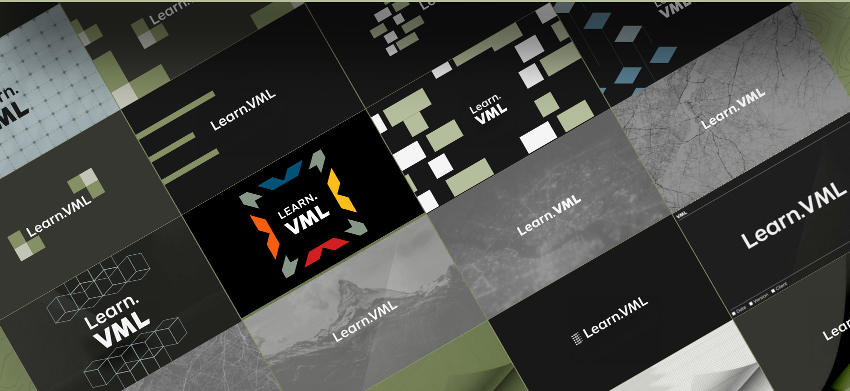
Get Started
We Are VML Elevated

Open Everydai Microseries

A practical, interactive, unique-to-VML playlist that's designed to help you put WPP Open to work in ways that actually save you time.

View Playlist
open everydai

The Brand Couldn't Look Like Training
It had to make people want to click. I started in black and white to avoid color bias, testing textures from paper to foundational bricks. With VML's VP, Global Head of Learning, we landed on elevation: growth, told through map topography and VML's full color palette.


Learn.VML
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LEARN.VML
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Date
Version
Client

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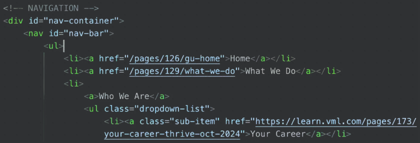
Customization

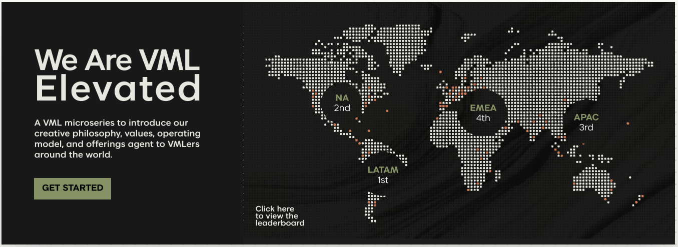
Where The LMS Stopped, I Coded

Docebo had no navigation bar or flexible hero section, so I coded both in HTML. The new hero held video, leaderboards, larger images, and longer copy, allowing room to promote initiatives like our Brandon Hall Award–winning Microlearning Challenge that brought nearly 12K visits in three months, triple the usual monthly traffic.

I pulled CSS selectors in dev tools to fix spacing platform-wide with my own code, and embedded VML's custom font via base64, giving every page the brand voice the platform's limits once constrained.



```
<!-- NAVIGATION -->
<div id="nav-container">
    <nav id="nav-bar">
        <ul>
            <li><a href="/pages/126/gu-home">Home</a></li>
            <li><a href="/pages/129/what-we-do">What We Do</a></li>
            <li>
                <a>Who We Are</a>
                <ul class="dropdown-list">
                    <li><a class="sub-item" href="https://learn.vml.com/pages/173/
                    your-career-thrive-oct-2024">Your Career</a></li>
```



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Elevated

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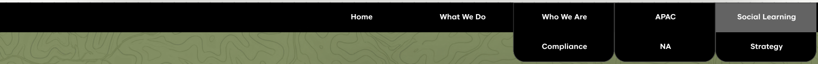
GET STARTED
NA
2nd
EMEA
4th
APAC
3rd
LATAM
1st
Click here to view the leaderboard


Home
What We Do
Who We Are
APAC
Social Learning
Compliance
NA
Strategy

89% Showed Up. Then They Stayed.

Stats reflect the first 10 months after launch.

89%	of employees logged in at least once
316%	increase in average learning time per user versus the old platform
230%	increase in unique monthly users compared to both legacy platforms combined
+431	additional courses created by regional teams, all inside the system

431 Courses Later, No Junk Drawer

What I'd Do Differently

I'd go back and properly name, tag, and organize my Figma layers after every big push. I spent this project teaching teams that good tagging is what makes content findable. My own files deserved the same rule. Clean layers would have made every later project, from branding new learning initiatives to new LMS pages, faster to build from.

2+ Years In

Revamping the LMS was my first major project at VML. It's since been at the heart of 10+ awards for the learning team, including Brandon Hall and even Docebo itself. The real test of a design system isn't launch day. It's whether it holds when other people start building. So far, so good.